MAKOLA.IO — REVENUE MODEL

How Makola Gets Paid

Two levers exist in the code. One number has never been decided. This is the model, and the decisions that are yours to make.

---

31 August 2026
Built from the source, not the strategy docs

Six pages
Replaces docs/BUSINESS_MODEL.md

Companions
Makola Reconciliation · Makola in Pictures

Free variable
Paystack Ghana's rate, still unconfirmed

01 — THE REVENUE SURFACE

Two levers. That is the entire business model in code.

Everything Makola can currently earn passes through two configuration values. Knowing exactly what they touch is the whole basis of the model.

LEVER ONE

`platform_fee_rate_bps`

Currently 200 — a flat 2% of the sale

Not set in any config file

→ **Normal orders — the merchant's own stock**

→ **Susu instalment plans — stamped when the plan opens**

→ **Protection holds — the buyer-protection rail**

LEVER TWO

`dropship_fee_rate_bps`

1000 — 10% of the margin, not the sale

→ **Dropship orders — a cut of the reseller's margin only**

One lever reaches three revenue surfaces. Change it once and normal sales, instalment plans and protected orders all move together. REPO `order_settlement.ex`, `susu_plan.ex`, `protection_holds.ex` all read the same key; `dropship_fee_rate_bps` is set in `config/config.exs`.

THE FINDING THAT MAKES THIS CHEAP TO FIX

`platform_fee_rate_bps` appears in **no configuration file** — not `config.exs`, not `runtime.exs`, not `prod.exs`. The 2% everyone is charged is a fallback default sitting in the source. Setting the fee is therefore **one new config line**, deployed like any other setting. No code change, no migration, no rewrite. REPO

WHAT IS NOT PLATFORM REVENUE

Affiliate commission

NOT OURS

The rate is set by each merchant on their own programme, and the money is carved out of the merchant's share. It is a merchant's marketing cost, not Makola's income.

Delivery fees

PASS-THROUGH

Collected from the buyer and passed to whoever delivers. Makola takes no cut.

Subscriptions

CANNOT BILL

Advertised on the live pricing page, but there is no mechanism to charge them. See page 03.

Keeping these out matters. A model padded with lines that never reach the platform account is how a plan ends up promising revenue that cannot arrive.

02 — THE FORMULA

What Makola keeps is the fee minus the gateway

The split sends the merchant's share to their wallet and leaves the remainder with Makola. Paystack's own charge is then taken from that remainder. So the model is one subtraction.

NET TAKE = F - G

F = the fee Makola sets · G = what Paystack charges on the collection

The merchant keeps 100% − F, and sees only that one number.

Today F = 2.0%. So Makola earns nothing at all unless Paystack charges less than 2%.

G has never been confirmed. It is the one number the whole model turns on.

Why the gateway lands on Makola and not the merchant: the split is built with `bearer_type: "account"`, which tells Paystack to take its charge from the main account — the remainder Makola keeps. REPO `paystack.ex:221`

THE FEE NEEDED TO REACH A GIVEN MARGIN

TARGET NET	G = 1.0%	G = 1.5%	G = 1.95%	G = 2.5%	PER MERCHANT	BREAK-EVEN
1.0%	2.00%	2.50%	2.95%	3.50%	GHS 80	125
2.0%	3.00%	3.50%	3.95%	4.50%	GHS 160	63
3.0%	4.00%	4.50%	4.95%	5.50%	GHS 240	42
Today — fixed 2%	2.00%	2.00%	2.00%	2.00%	GHS 80 → 4	125 → 2,500

Each cell is the fee **F** to set for that margin at that gateway rate. Read the row you want, then the column once Paystack confirms G. **Per merchant** is monthly platform revenue from one merchant; **break-even** is how many such merchants reach GHS 10,000 a month. MODEL Per-merchant and break-even figures assume GHS 8,000 of monthly sales per merchant — an assumption, not a measurement. The bottom row shows what today's fixed 2% yields as G rises.

TWO WAYS TO IMPLEMENT IT

Raise F, leave the gateway on Makola RECOMMENDED

Merchant sees one number and keeps 100% − F. Makola absorbs Paystack out of a bigger cut. **One config line, no code.** Better for a merchant who cannot easily read a deduction breakdown.

Move the gateway charge onto the merchant ALTERNATIVE

Set the split to bill the merchant's subaccount. Makola keeps a clean F. But the merchant now sees two deductions, and their payout varies with a rate they do not control. **Requires a code change in `paystack.ex`.**

Both routes reach the same margin. The first is free, ships faster, and keeps the promise to a low-literacy merchant down to a single sentence — which is the same reason the checkout asks one thing at a time. REPO The exact deduction mechanics of a Paystack split should be confirmed against their documentation at the same time as the rate.

03 — WHERE THE CURRENT PRICES CAME FROM

The pricing was never chosen. It was inherited.

Before setting a price it is worth knowing that the current one was not set at all. It arrived with the template the project was scaffolded from.

WHAT config/plans.exs ACTUALLY SAYS

"Starter"
price_cents: 2900
"5 workspaces"
"10 AI agents"
"10,000 API calls/month"

"Pro"
price_cents: 7900
"50 AI agents"
"100,000 API calls/month"

WHAT GHANAIAN MERCHANTS ARE SHOWN

Growth
GHS 29
"2.0% per sale"

Pro
GHS 79
"1.2% per sale"

Same numbers. Currency symbol swapped.

29 and 79 were dollars in a SaaS boilerplate that sold AI agents and API calls. They now appear on a Ghanaian commerce site as cedis. No pricing research produced them, and GHS 29 is roughly a fifteenth of USD 29 in value — so even the relative positioning carried no meaning across. **REPO** `config/plans.exs` against `pricing_live.ex`.

WHAT THIS CHANGES

The task on the pricing page is not *correcting* a price. It is **setting one for the first time**, for this market, on purpose. That is a better position to be in than it sounds — nothing is being walked back, because nothing was ever decided.

WHY A MONTHLY FEE IS THE WRONG OPENING MOVE REGARDLESS

The segment is subscription-averse
DEMAND

A small cut of a sale they would otherwise fumble is an easy yes. A monthly charge before any sale has happened is a hard no. The project's own June strategy reached this conclusion and it still holds.

It cannot be charged anyway
CANNOT BILL

Billing runs on Stripe scaffolding that does not operate in Ghana, and the Paystack handler is an empty stub. Building recurring billing is weeks of work.

Two numbers are harder than one
LITERACY

A merchant who reads with difficulty can hold "you keep most of every sale". A monthly fee plus a percentage plus a tier is three things to track.

04 — THE MODEL OVER TIME

One number now. Tiers only when they are earned.

The model has three phases, and each is gated on evidence rather than a date. Nothing in a later phase should be built before its gate opens.

PHASE ONE — NOW, UNTIL THERE IS REVENUE

DO THIS NOW

One free tier. One all-in percentage. No subscription.

Build cost: one config line. Gate to open it: none — this is available today.

gate: 20 merchants transacting weekly

PHASE TWO — ONLY ONCE PHASE ONE HAS PAYING VOLUME

Pay monthly to lower your percentage

Build cost: Paystack recurring billing from scratch — weeks, not a switch. The Stripe scaffolding is unusable.

gate: counsel answers the custody question

PHASE THREE — THE LINES ALREADY BUILT BUT UNPRICED

Dropship margin fee · buyer-protection holds · susu instalment plans · the supplier network

Phase three needs no new product. All four surfaces exist and already read a fee rate — they are unpriced rather than unbuilt. They are placed last because each one holds money for longer than a normal sale does, which is precisely what the custody question governs.

THE PHASE ONE OFFER, AS A MERCHANT WOULD HEAR IT

> "It costs nothing to open your shop. When someone buys, you keep most of the money and we take a small part. If you sell nothing, you pay nothing."
>
> One sentence, no tiers, no monthly charge, no arithmetic. The exact percentage goes in once the gateway rate is known — see the decisions on page 06.

The cost base is hours, not cedis

At this size the money cost of serving a merchant is close to nothing. The binding cost is founder time, and it should be modelled as such rather than dressed up as a cash figure.

COST TO SERVE

Application server	1 small machine
Database	1 small instance
Marginal cost per merchant	≈ 0
Gateway cost	G, per sale

Gross margin at low volume is decided almost entirely by G, not by hosting. Infrastructure becomes a real cost only well past the merchant counts on page 02. REPO `fly.toml`

ACQUISITION COST, IN HOURS

Messages per onboarded seller	≈ 10
Outreach time per day	30–45 min
To reach 10–15 sellers	≈ 2 weeks
Cash spend	GHS 0

Derived from the funnel already written down: 100–150 personalised messages, roughly 10–20% reply, about half converting. REPO `docs/GTM-FOUNDING-SELLERS.md`. A cash acquisition cost cannot be stated because no money has been spent acquiring anyone.

THE CUSTODY ANSWER CHANGES THE FUNNEL, NOT JUST THE RISK REGISTER

If counsel finds the internal-hold path cannot be the default, then every merchant must complete payout onboarding **and** pass Paystack's subaccount verification **before** their first sale — instead of after it, as today.

That inserts a verification wait into the funnel at its most fragile point: between a seller saying yes and their first order arriving. It lengthens time-to-first-sale, which is the metric most predictive of whether a founding seller stays. The commercial consequence of the legal question is a slower funnel, and it is worth knowing before it arrives.

METRICS — SPLIT BY WHETHER THEY CAN BE MEASURED YET

MEASURABLE ONCE KEYS ARE LIVE
Effective take rate (F − G, observed)
GMV processed
Platform fee collected
Merchants transacting weekly
Time from signup to first sale
Payment success rate

NEEDS MONTHS OF DATA THAT DO NOT EXIST
Churn
Lifetime value
LTV to CAC ratio
Net promoter score

The retired `BUSINESS_MODEL.md` carried targets for all four. They were written before a single merchant transacted and should not be projected forward — quote them to nobody.

Four decisions, and what each one turns on

These are commercial choices, not engineering ones. The trade-offs are set out; the calls are yours.

1 — What margin should Makola target?

Pick a row on page 02. A 2% net take needs 63 merchants at the assumed volume to reach GHS 10,000 a month; a 1% net take needs 125. Higher is better commercially and worse competitively — the honest comparison is not Shopify but a merchant's own MoMo number, which costs them nothing.

Turns on: how much friction the segment tolerates before doing nothing instead.

2 — Who bears the gateway charge?

Leaving it on Makola and raising F keeps the merchant's experience to one number and costs one config line. Moving it onto the merchant keeps a clean margin but needs a code change and shows the merchant a deduction they cannot control.

Turns on: whether you would rather protect the margin or the single-number promise. The recommendation on page 02 is the single number, because it is free and it matches the literacy commitment everywhere else in the product.

3 — Do the paid tiers stay on the pricing page?

They cannot be billed today. Leaving them up quotes a price that cannot be honoured. Taking them down is an hour's work and costs nothing, because no one has ever bought one.

Turns on: nothing, in truth. This one only looks like a decision.

4 — Founding-seller rate: permanent or introductory?

The outreach script already promises founding sellers “the lowest rate forever”. Honouring that permanently caps the revenue from the first cohort, who are also the cohort most likely to refer others. Making it introductory instead is more flexible but weakens the offer at the exact moment it needs to convert.

Turns on: whether the first twenty sellers are worth more as revenue or as advocates. Decide before the first message is sent, not after.

THE ONE THING THAT MUST HAPPEN FIRST

Every number above resolves the moment Paystack Ghana confirms its mobile-money collection rate. Until then the model is a formula with a hole in it — usable for structure, not for setting a price. **That confirmation is one email, and it unblocks decisions 1, 2 and 4 at once.**

`REPO` Read from source: both fee rates and every surface that consumes them, the split construction, the plan definitions, the live pricing page, the funnel maths, and the infrastructure configuration. `MODEL` GHS 8,000 of monthly sales per merchant and GHS 10,000 of monthly platform revenue are reference assumptions for arithmetic, not forecasts. Paystack Ghana's rate and Act 987's licence threshold lie outside the repository and must come from those parties directly.